

SHOULD DO

T HAS TO SET STIFF TARGETS AND PUSH FOR A NEW GLOBAL COMPACT BASED ON EQUITY.

■ By Raj Chengappa

Politically the climate may not have been right. After all, the future of Prime Minister Manmohan Singh and his UPA Government lay balanced on a knife's edge as the Left parties threatened to withdraw support if he went ahead with the Indo-US civilian nuclear deal. In many ways though the situation was quite similar to what the globe confronted while dealing with rapid climate change: The tipping point to disaster was fast approaching and the time to act was now. Or it would be too late.

Putting on a brave face that masked much of the political turmoil, on June 30 Manmohan released India's most important statement on the global warming crisis: the much-awaited National Action Plan on Climate Change. Worked on for over a year, the plan laid out eight critical missions or thrust areas ranging from harnessing solar energy to saving the Himalayan ecology. These would help the country mitigate and if need be adapt to the debilitating impact of climate change (*see chart*). Global warming is caused by the accumulation of Green House Gases (GHG) like carbon dioxide and methane in the atmosphere resulting in a rise in the earth's overall surface temperatures. Carbon dioxide is released into the atmosphere when fossil fuel is burnt.

The emphasis of the report was on renewable energy and to considerably lessen India's dependence on fossil fuel-based options in the long run. India also signalled to the world that it believed in an equitable and fair approach to international climate change negotiations with the prime minister stating that "every citizen of this planet must have an equal share of the planetary atmospheric space". He renewed his pledge that India's per capita GHG emissions will not exceed that of developed countries.

It is important that India plays a lead in getting developed countries to act because as a low latitude country, the subcontinent would face much of the misery that climate change would wreak. Rainfall pattern is expected to undergo a major change with areas like Kerala, Madhya Pradesh and the North-east getting less moisture. There is also a major shift expected in the forest patterns with India's dense woods giving way to scrub jungle in

5%

Expected rise in global surface temperature by the end of the century

25

billion tonne of carbon emissions need to be cut to contain warming

2012

The year when Kyoto Protocol to cut carbon emissions expires

55%

of world's carbon emissions is produced by 15% of population

\$380

billion is the likely cost in 2030 to return world emissions to 2007 levels